

Simplifying How NJ Business Owners Discover Funding and Certification Opportunities

State of New Jersey | Innovation Authority

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Keywords

Dashboard design, wizard ui pattern, content mapping & tagging

Summary

Business.NJ.gov is a one-stop hub where over 240,000 business owners apply for licenses and permits, manage their compliance, and find the latest updates on policy changes that may affect their business. The current account dashboard lists undifferentiated opportunities in a long scrollable list, making it nearly impossible for users to identify which optional resources are actually worth pursuing for their specific goals. Nicole's discovery and redesign improves business owners' browsing experience through a profile customization wizard and increased transparency into opportunity benefits.

Simplifying How NJ Business Owners Discover Funding and Certification Opportunities

Business Experience Team
State of New Jersey – Innovation Authority
Hannah Pingol — Product Designer

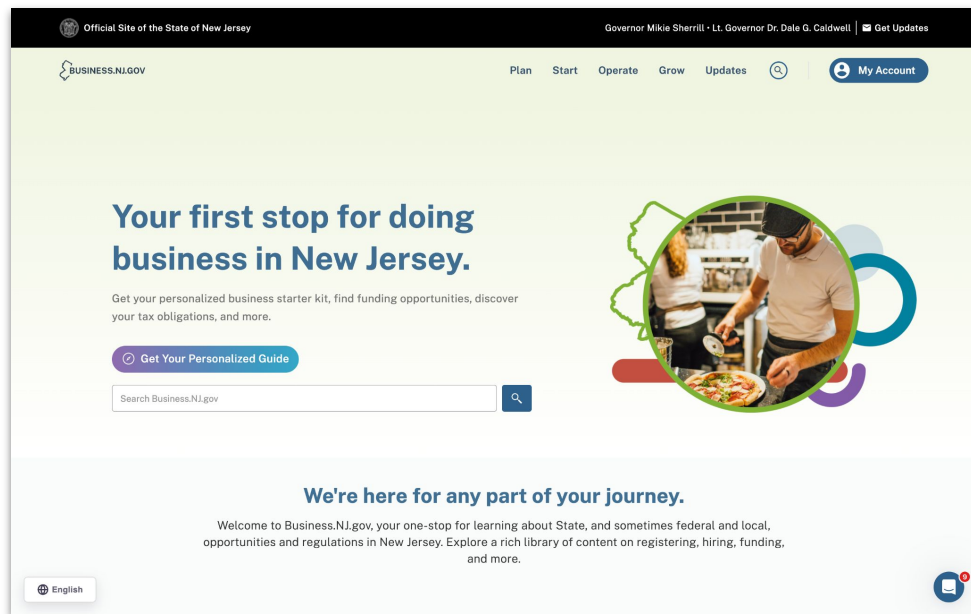
coding it forward >



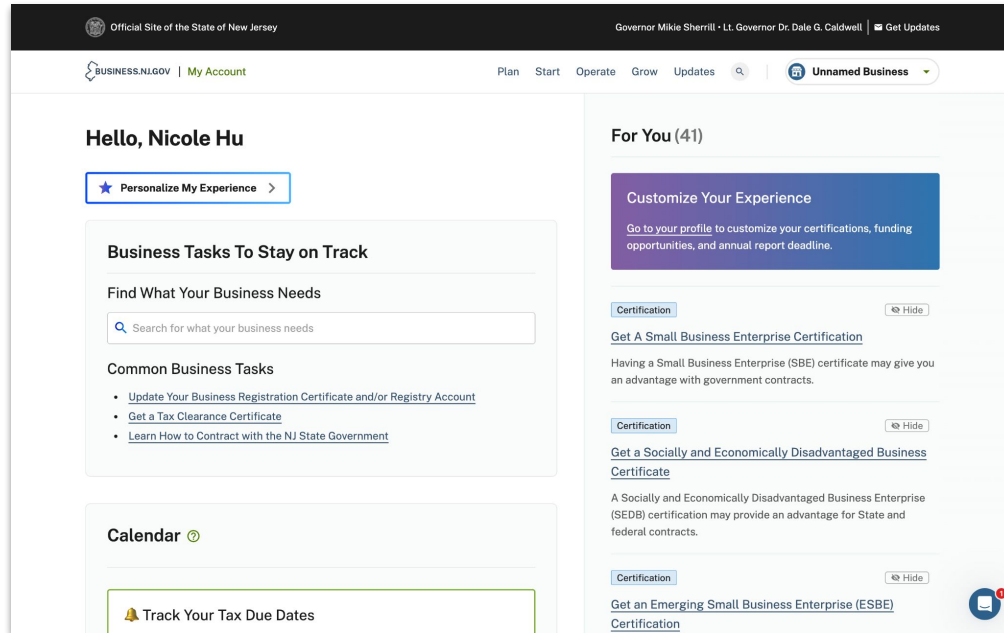
NICOLE HU
New York University
Political Economy & Design

WHAT IS BUSINESS.NJ.GOV?

Business.NJ.gov is a one-stop hub where over 240,000 business owners apply for licenses and permits, find the latest updates on policy changes, and learn about funding and certifications they may qualify for.



CURRENT EXPERIENCE



For onboarded users within My Account, tasks and deadlines are on the left, while optional funding opportunities and certifications, are in a “For You” column on the right

CURRENT EXPERIENCE

The screenshot displays the 'My Account' page on the BUSINESS.NJ.GOV website. The top navigation bar includes links for Plan, Start, Operate, Grow, and Updates, along with a search icon and a dropdown menu for 'Unnamed Business'. The main content area is divided into two columns. The left column features a 'Common Business Tasks' section with links to 'Update Your Business Registration Certificate and/or Registry Account', 'Get a Tax Clearance Certificate', and 'Learn How to Contract with the NJ State Government'. Below this is a 'Calendar' section with a 'Track Your Tax Due Dates' alert and a 'Step 1 of 2' registration process for Gov2Go, which includes a 'Business Structure' dropdown menu and a 'Next' button. The right column lists several certification options, each with a brief description: 'Get a Small Business Enterprise Certification', 'Get a Socially and Economically Disadvantaged Business Certificate', 'Get an Emerging Small Business Enterprise (ESBE) Certification', 'Get an Urban Enterprise Zone (UEZ) Certification', and 'Get Certified as a Disabled Veteran-Owned Business'. A notification icon is visible in the bottom right corner.

BUSINESS.NJ.GOV | My Account

Plan Start Operate Grow Updates

Unnamed Business

Common Business Tasks

- [Update Your Business Registration Certificate and/or Registry Account](#)
- [Get a Tax Clearance Certificate](#)
- [Learn How to Contract with the NJ State Government](#)

Calendar

Track Your Tax Due Dates

To get access, we need to collect some information and register you with Gov2Go.

Step 1 of 2

Business Structure

Next

It looks like you do not have any filings for the next 12 months. Check back later.

Get a Small Business Enterprise Certification

Having a Small Business Enterprise (SBE) certificate may give you an advantage with government contracts.

Certification

Get a Socially and Economically Disadvantaged Business Certificate

A Socially and Economically Disadvantaged Business Enterprise (SEDB) certification may provide an advantage for State and federal contracts.

Certification

Get an Emerging Small Business Enterprise (ESBE) Certification

Emerging Small Business Enterprise (ESBE) certification facilitates competition by small businesses for New Jersey Department of Transportation's (...)

Certification

Get an Urban Enterprise Zone (UEZ) Certification

An Urban Enterprise Zone (UEZ) certification offers a reduced sales tax rate and other benefits to qualified businesses.

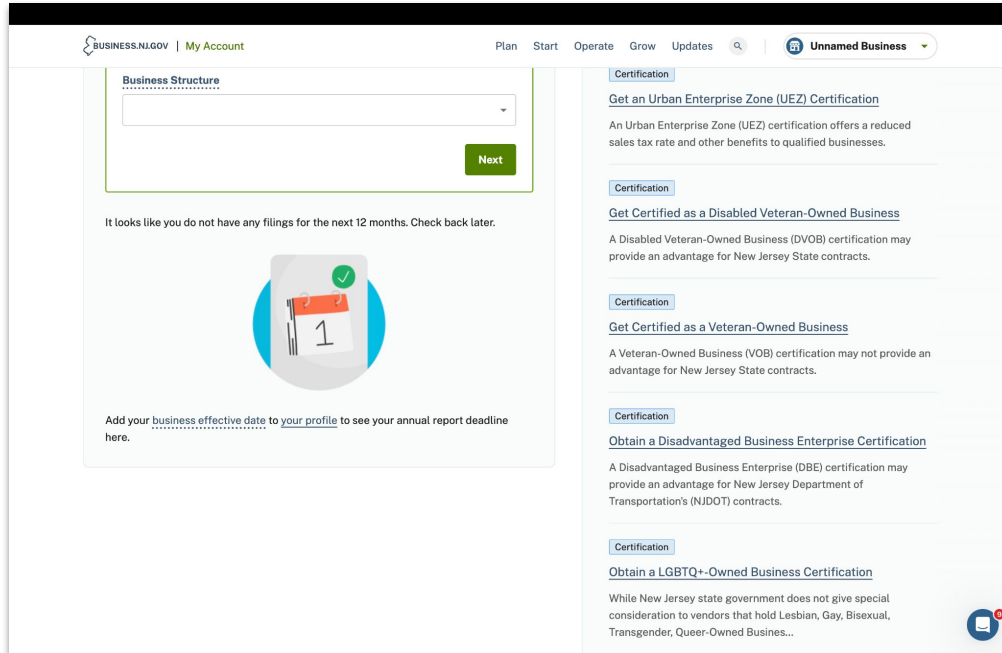
Certification

Get Certified as a Disabled Veteran-Owned Business

A Disabled Veteran-Owned Business (DVOB) certification may provide an advantage for New Jersey State contracts.

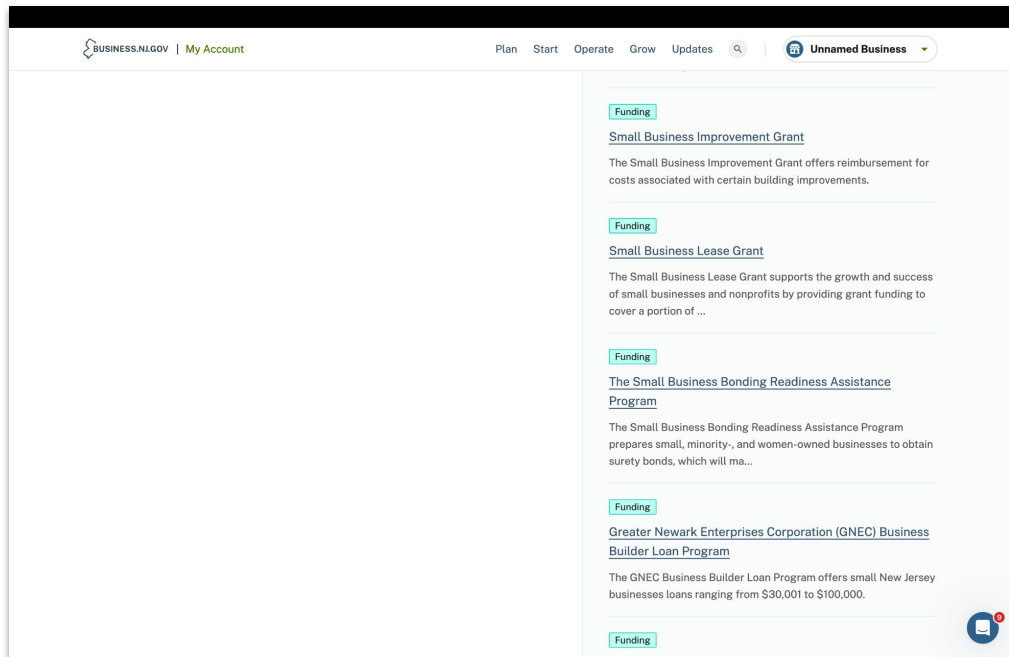
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CURRENT EXPERIENCE



For onboarded users within My Account, tasks and deadlines are on the left, while optional funding opportunities and certifications, are in a “For You” column on the right

CURRENT EXPERIENCE



The current "For You" column presents up to 60 undifferentiated options in a long scrollable list.

This makes it difficult for business owners to determine which are actually worth pursuing for their specific goals.

THE CHALLENGE

Registered business owners need a better way to identify valuable certifications and funding opportunities they qualify for and can benefit from in the My Account dashboard

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BUSINESS.GOV

Plan Start Operate Grow Updates My Account

OPERATE

MWBE, SBE, VOB and Other Certifications

Business certifications can give you certain advantages with some local, state, and federal contracting opportunities, among other benefits. Learn if one of the State's certifications is the right fit for your business.

[View Your Personalized Tax Calendar](#)

Page path + query string	Active us...
1. /pages/register-your-business	132,299
2. /pages/filings-and-accounting	68,457
3. /pages/business-names	51,597
4. /pages/closing-your-business	37,594
5. /pages/register-for-taxes	32,936
6. /pages/government-contracting	30,858
7. /pages/covid19	26,659
8. /pages/out-of-state-business-registration	24,290
9. /pages/choose-a-business-structure	18,163
10. /pages/mwbe	14,564
11. /pages/certifications	14,281
12. /pages/create-a-business-plan	12,648
13. /pages/finance-your-business	8,510
14. /pages/employer-requirements	8,497
15. /pages/building-permits-and-inspections	7,758
Grand total	480,714

Discrete > MWBE, SBE, VOB and Other Certifications

Contents

- Minority and Economically Disadvantaged Business (MEBD) Certification
- Minority-Owned Business or Enterprise (MOBE) Certification
- Woman-Owned Business (WOBE) and Disabled Veteran-Owned Business (DVOB)
- Small Business Enterprise (SBE)
- Prime Small Business Enterprise (PSBE) and Disadvantaged Business Enterprise (DBE)

Back to Top

How might we surface the most **relevant opportunities** without requiring business owners to scroll through dozens of options in the For You column?

DESIGN GOALS

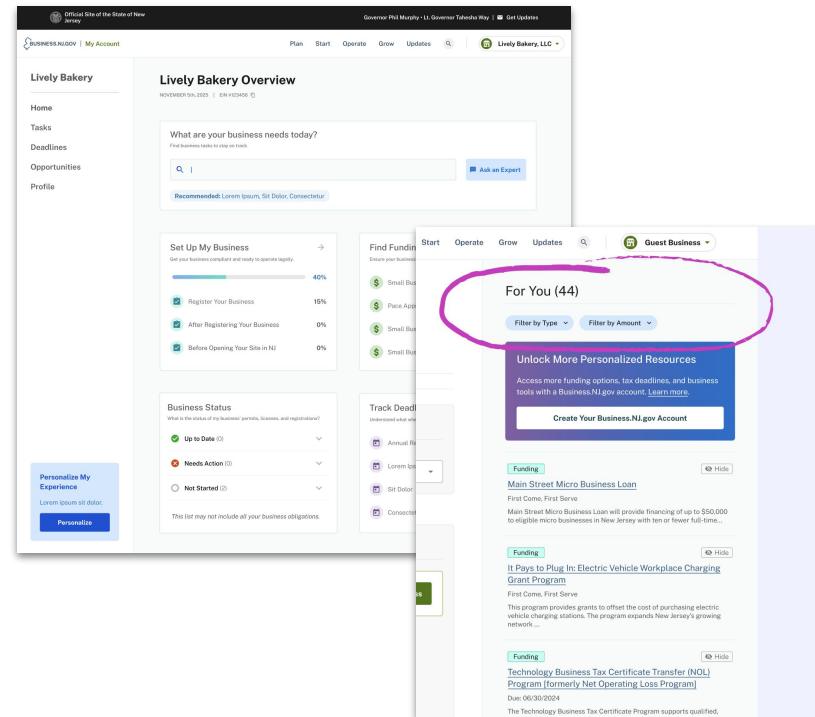
- ★ **Differentiating between urgent vs optional vs recommended opportunities**
- ★ **Highlighting the value proposition of each opportunity**
- ★ **Clearly communicating why opportunities were recommended to users**



BUILDING CONTEXT

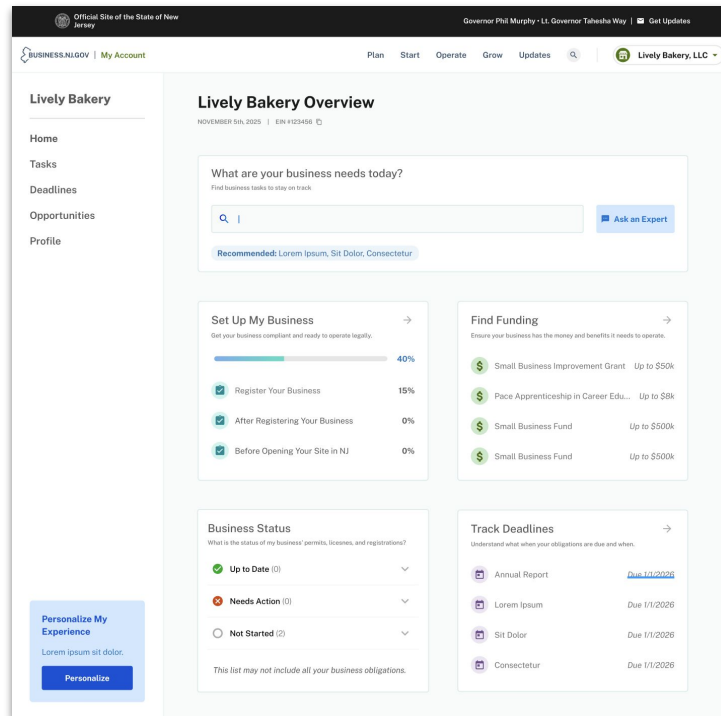
Started by documenting previous discovery and past designs

- Consulted with 4 designers and product manager on the business experience initiative
- Read through old tickets and reviewed previous user interview/testing insights



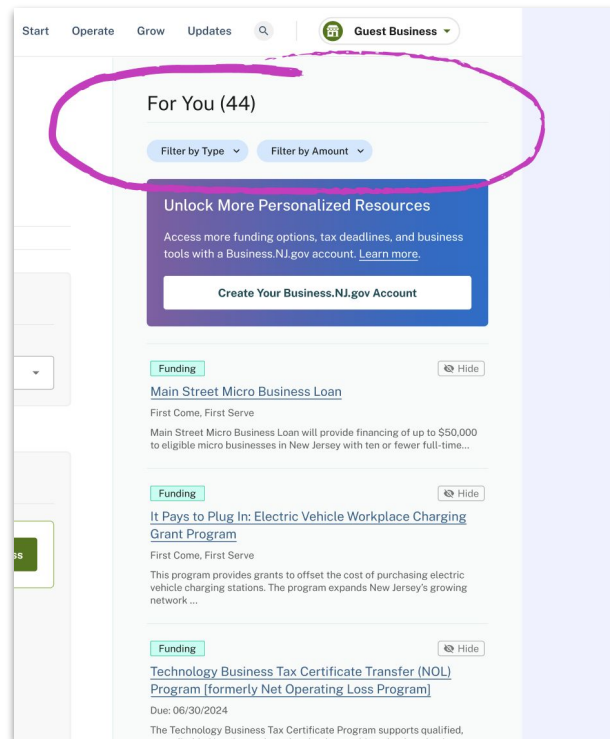
BUILDING CONTEXT

- 1) There is a parallel effort to redesign My Account dashboard entirely, getting rid of For You column
- 2) Past efforts have proposed filtering within the For You column



BUILDING CONTEXT

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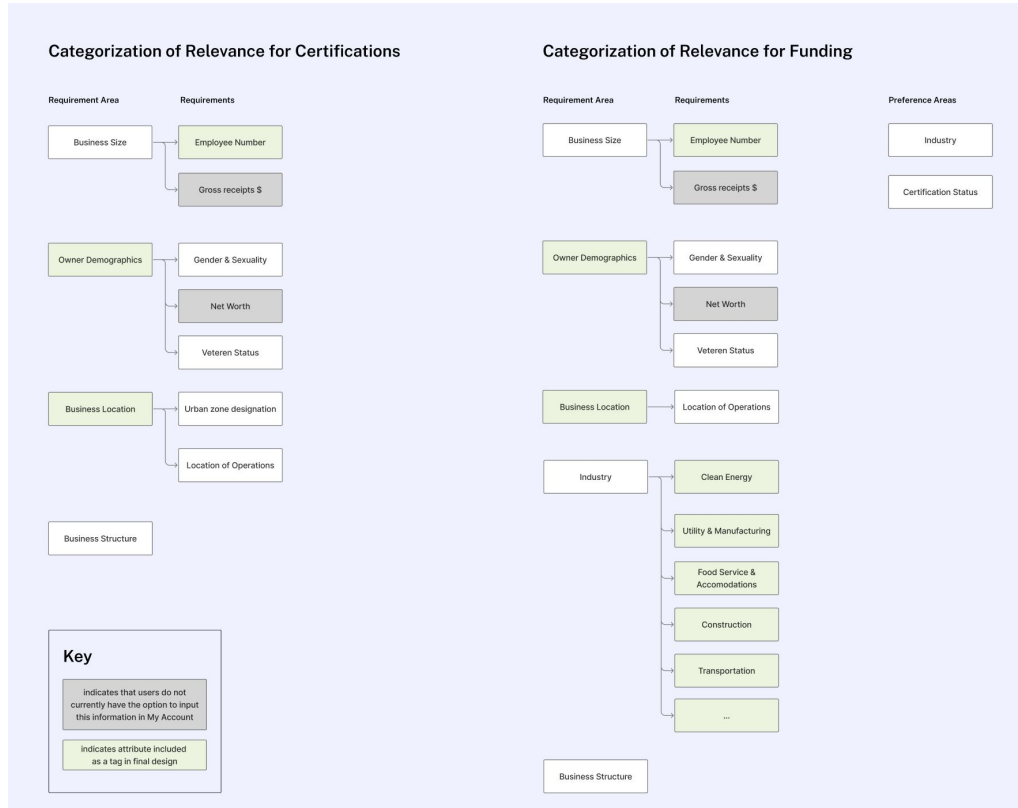
REVISING GOALS

Our focus is on experimenting with **design patterns** applicable **even if future dashboard designs move away from the For You column.**



FEATURE #1: SMART TAGGING

UNDERSTANDING RELEVANCE



Relevance considers the likelihood that a business owner qualifies for an opportunity

Mapping is based on eligibility requirements and preferences of opportunities currently listed on b.nj.gov

NEW CARD DESIGN

Funding

Hide

Entrepreneur Support Program

First Come, First Serve

The New Jersey Entrepreneur Support Program provides a \$5 million fund to guarantee investor loans for working capital, up to a total of \$400,000 p...



Tax Credit

Hide

Entrepreneur Support Program

First Come, First Serve

The New Jersey Entrepreneur Support Program provides a \$5 million fund to guarantee investor loans for working capital, up to a total of \$400,000 p...

✓ Life Sciences

✓ Under 50 employees

NEW CARD DESIGN

Label specifies the
type of opportunity
(funding -> tax credit)

Tax Credit

Hide

Entrepreneur Support Program
First Come, First Serve
The New Jersey Entrepreneur Support Program provides a \$5 million fund to guarantee investor loans for working capital, up to a total of \$400,000 p...

✓ Life Sciences

✓ Under 50 employees

Tags signal
relevance of each
opportunity

FEATURE #2: FILTERS

CONTINUING PAST EXPLORATION

Filter by Type ▾

Filter by Type ▲

- ☒ Certifications
- ☒ Grant
- ☒ Investment
- ☒ Loan
- ☒ Tax Credit
- ☒ Technical Assistance
- ☒ Hiring & Employee Training Support

Additional Opportunities

Filter by Type ▾ Filter by Industry ▾

Certification Hide

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Certification Hide

Get A Small Business Enterprise Certification

Having a Small Business Enterprise (SBE) certificate may give you an advantage with government contracts.

Loan Hide

Main Street Micro Business Loan

First Come, First Serve

Main Street Micro Business Loan will provide financing of up to \$50,000 to eligible micro businesses in New Jersey with ten or fewer full-time...

Technical Assistance Hide

The Small Business Bonding Readiness Assistance Program

First Come, First Serve

Small businesses, with particular emphasis on minority- and women-owned businesses, may apply.

Filters allow users to tailor the list of opportunities based on their priorities

Differentiation between funding and certifications under Opportunities

FEATURE #3: PERSONALIZATION WIZARD

CURRENT FLOW

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BUSINESS.NJ.GOV | My Account Plan Start Operate Grow Updates Unnamed Business

Hello, Nicole Hu

★ Personalize My Experience >

Business Tasks To Stay on Track

Find What Your Business Needs

Search for what your business needs

Common Business Tasks

- Update Your Business Registration Certificate and/or Registry Account
- Get a Tax Clearance Certificate
- Learn How to Contract with the NJ State Government

Calendar

Track Your Tax Due Dates

For You (41)

Customize Your Experience
Go to your profile to customize your certifications, funding opportunities, and annual report deadline.

Certification Hide

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Having a Small Business Enterprise (SBE) certificate may give you an advantage with government contracts.

Certification Hide

Get a Socially and Economically Disadvantaged Business Certificate
A Socially and Economically Disadvantaged Business Enterprise (SEDB) certification may provide an advantage for State and federal contracts.

Certification Hide

Get an Emerging Small Business Enterprise (ESBE) Certification

41



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[Go Back](#)

Profile For Unnamed Business

Your profile helps us make recommendations for your business.

Business Information

Business Name

Business Address

Address Line 1

Address Line 2 (Optional)

City **State** **Zip Code**

Business Information

- Contact & Notifications >
- Permits & Licenses >
- Reference Numbers >
- Notes >
- ★ Personalize My Experience >

41

CURRENT FLOW

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BUSINESS.NJ.GOV | My Account Plan Start Operate Grow Updates Unnamed Business

Hello, Nicole Hu

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BUSINESS.NJ.GOV | My Account Plan Start Operate Grow Updates Unnamed Business

Go Back

Profile For Unnamed Business

Your profile helps us make recommendations for your business.

- Business Information >
- Contact & Notifications >
- Permits & Licenses >
- Reference Numbers >
- Notes >

Personalize My Experience

Answer a few questions to find out what licenses and permits you may need and discover funding programs to help your business grow. New items will appear on your Starter Kit or your For You section.

Add Your Annual Report Deadline

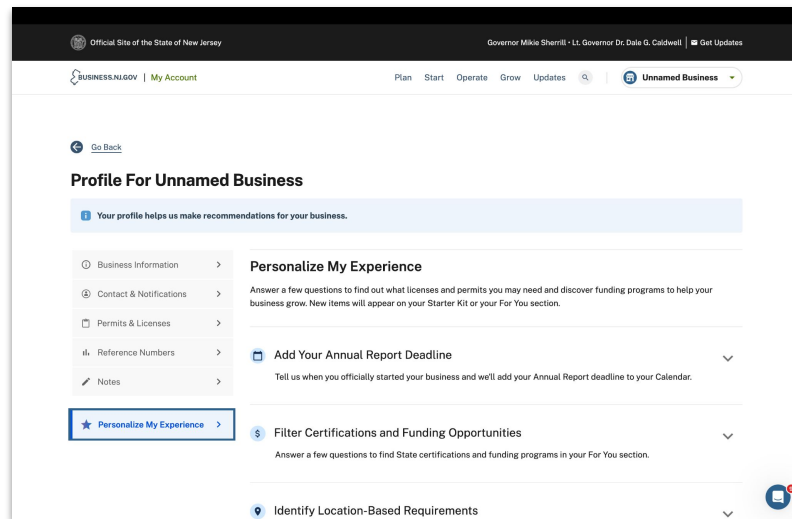
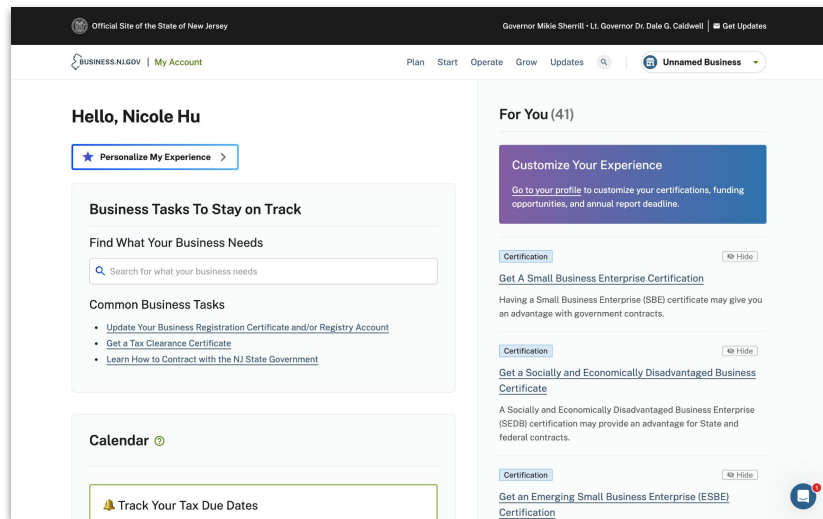
Tell us when you officially started your business and we'll add your Annual Report deadline to your Calendar.

Filter Certifications and Funding Opportunities

Answer a few questions to find State certifications and funding programs in your For You section.

Identify Location-Based Requirements

CURRENT FLOW



WIZARD FLOW

Personalize your experience

Answer 3 quick questions so we can surface the certifications, grants, and resources most relevant to your business.

[Get Started](#)

[No Thanks](#)

To personalize your recommendations, go to [my profile](#)

Personalize your experience

Question 1 of 3

How many employees does your business have?

- ☐ Just me
- ☐ 2-10 employees
- ☐ 11-50 employees
- ☐ 51-250 employees
- ☐ 251+ employees

[Back](#)

[Continue](#)

Personalize your experience

Question 2 of 3

Where is your business located?

Street Address

City ZIP

Country

[Back](#)

[Continue](#)

Personalize your experience

Question 3 of 3

Tell us about your business owner(s)

Used only to match you with eligible programs

- ☐ Veteran-Owned
SBA+ owned by a U.S. military veteran
- ☐ Women-Owned
SBA+ owned by a woman
- ☐ Minority-Owned
SBA+ owned by a racial or ethnic minority
- ☐ LGBTQ+ Owned
SBA+ owned as LGBTQ+ individual
- ☐ Disability-Owned
SBA+ owned by a person with a disability

[Back](#)

[Finish](#)

Your dashboard is personalized!

We've updated your results based on your answers. You can refine this anytime in [your profile](#).

Personalize your experience

Question 1 of 3

How many employees does your business have?

- ☐ Just me
- ☐ 2-10 employees
- ☒ 11-50 employees
- ☐ 51-250 employees
- ☐ 251+ employees

[Back](#)

[Continue](#)

Personalize your experience

Question 2 of 3

Where is your business located?

Street Address
123 Main St

Street Address ZIP

Fort Lee 07024

Country
Regen

[Back](#)

[Continue](#)

Personalize your experience

Question 3 of 3

Tell us about your business owner(s)

Used only to match you with eligible programs

- ☐ Veteran-Owned
SBA+ owned by a U.S. military veteran
- ☒ Women-Owned
SBA+ owned by a woman
- ☒ Minority-Owned
SBA+ owned by a racial or ethnic minority
- ☐ LGBTQ+ Owned
SBA+ owned as LGBTQ+ individual
- ☐ Disability-Owned
SBA+ owned by a person with a disability

[Back](#)

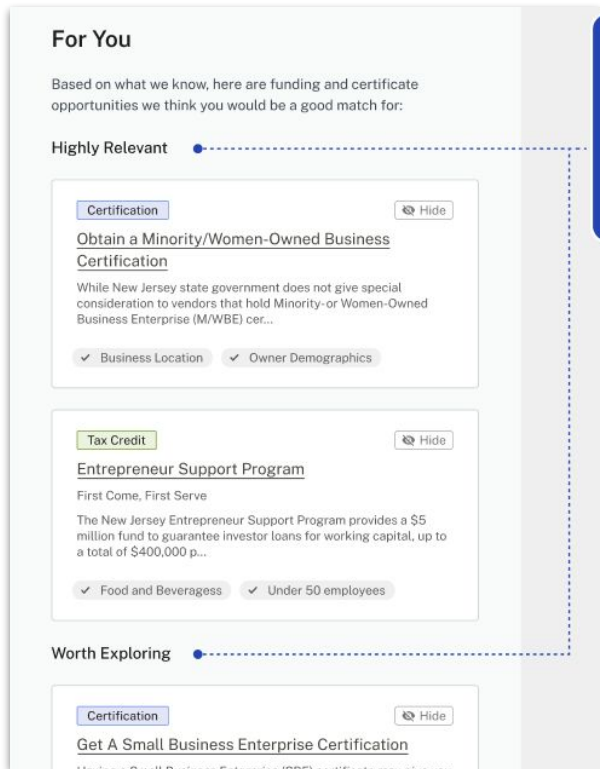
[Finish](#)

[Prototype Link](#)

DISCARDED DESIGN

Tiered recommendations

In testing, users felt confused about what's “worth exploring” and were unclear about why they were shown these options



FINAL RECOMMENDATION

We can give users a better experience navigating funding and certifications through:

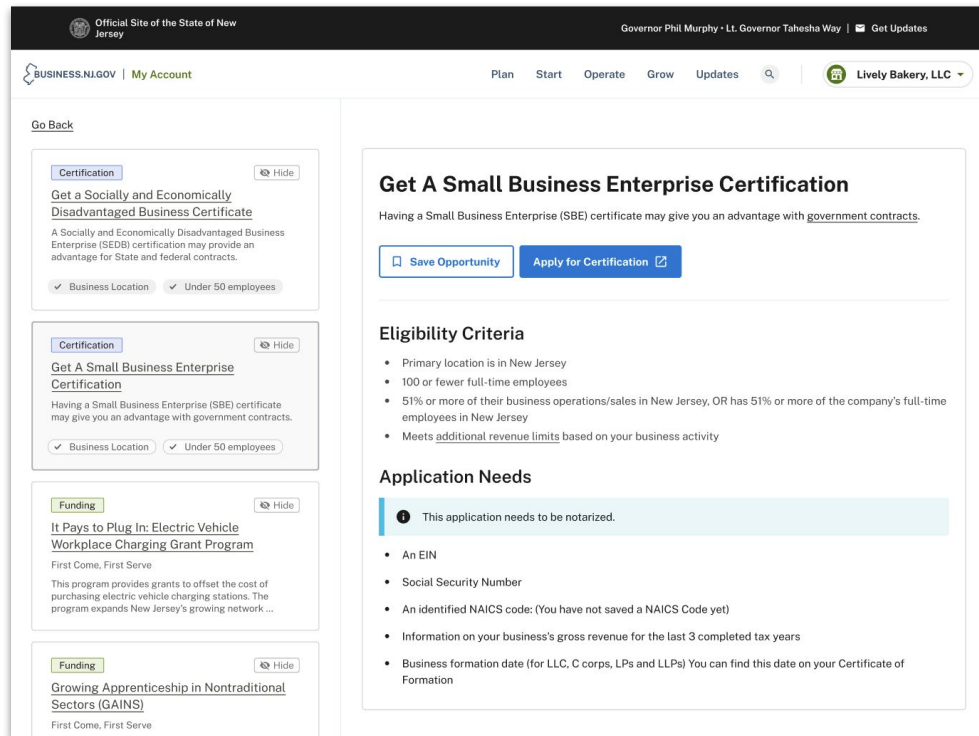
- 1) Giving users more agency over their experience**
- 2) Clearer communication on what experiences are being personalized**



NEXT STEPS

Continue exploring future state designs that include:

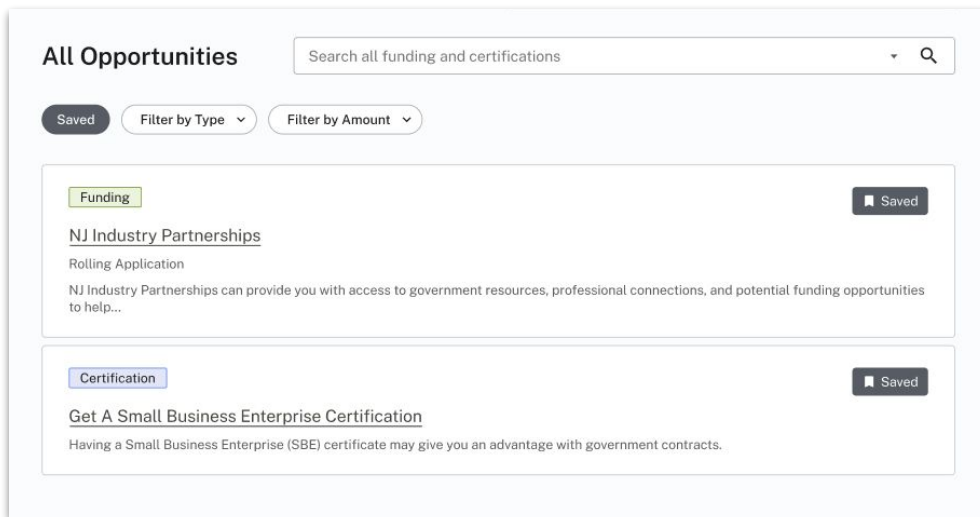
- Multi-opportunity browsing experience
- Bookmarking feature
- Activity history and tracking



NEXT STEPS

Continue exploring future state designs that include:

- **Multi-opportunity browsing experience**
- **Bookmarking feature**
- **Activity history and tracking**



NEXT STEPS

Continue exploring future state designs that include:

- **Multi-opportunity browsing experience**
- **Bookmarking feature**
- **Activity history and tracking**

The screenshot displays a user interface with two main sections: 'For You' and 'Your Activity History'.

For You

Based on what we know, here are funding and certificate opportunities we think you would be a good match for:

Certification (with a 'Hide' button)

Obtain a Minority/Women-Owned Business Certification

While New Jersey state government does not give special consideration to vendors that hold Minority- or Women-Owned Business Enterprise (M/WBE) cer...

✓ Business Location ✓ Owner Demographics

Tax Credit (with a 'Hide' button)

Entrepreneur Support Program

First Come, First Serve

The New Jersey Entrepreneur Support Program provides a \$5 million fund to guarantee investor loans for working capital, up to a total of \$400,000 p...

✓ Food and Beveragess ✓ Under 50 employees

Your Activity History

Hiring & Employee Training Support

The Small Business Bonding Readiness Assistance Program

DUE DATE: 3/15/2026

Last visited 2/12/2026

Loan

Small Business Fund

First Come, First Serve

Applied 2/23/2026

LEARNINGS/REFLECTION

- 1) **Get feedback early and throughout**
- 2) **UX and content design are inseparable**



Collaboration is
multiplication.

John C. Maxwell

“quotezany”

THANK YOU!

A special gratitude to Hannah Pingol for her mentorship and guidance; the BisX team and the design community at NJIA for their support throughout this fellowship; and to Coding it Forward, Cassie and my fellow Fellows, for making this learning experience especially meaningful!